

VICTORIA MOOERS

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ACADEMIC APPOINTMENTS

2025– Assistant Professor, University of Oklahoma, Department of Economics
2025–2026 Postdoctoral Scholar, University of Chicago, Mansueto Institute for Urban Innovation & Harris School

EDUCATION

2025	Ph.D.	Economics	Columbia University
2022	M.Phil.	Economics	Columbia University
2021	M.A.	Economics	Columbia University
2016	B.A.	Economics, Public Policy (with honors)	University of Chicago

FIELDS OF SPECIALIZATION

Applied Microeconomics, Political Economy, Experimental Economics, Public Economics

WORKING PAPERS

Social Networks and Voter Information

Abstract: Informed voters are essential for government accountability, and social networks are an important avenue through which voters acquire political information. However, U.S. congressional districts do not need to align with social networks, potentially impacting how easily voters learn about their representatives. I study whether the alignment between district boundaries and social networks affects voter knowledge and turnout in congressional elections. Using Facebook's Social Connectedness Index and an event study design, I find that an increase in the share of friends living in the same district increases voters' knowledge about their representative. For example, a 10-percentage point (one standard deviation) increase in this share raises the probability that a voter knows their representative's party by 3.3 percentage points, a 5% increase over the mean. Additionally, a higher share of friends in the same district decreases voter abstention, and shifts campaign contributions towards in-district candidates. I use a model of information diffusion to simulate the share of informed voters under counterfactual district maps, creating a framework to evaluate the informational effects of proposed maps. These findings suggest that aligning political boundaries with social networks can enhance democratic engagement.

Liquid Democracy or Direct Democracy? One Theoretical Result and Two Experiments, with Joseph Campbell, Alessandra Casella, Lucas de Lara, and Dilip Ravindran. <https://arxiv.org/abs/2212.09715>

Abstract: Proponents of participatory democracy praise Liquid Democracy: decisions are taken by referendum, but voters delegate their votes freely. When better informed voters are present and the electorate is finite, we show theoretically that delegation can always strictly increase the probability of a correct decision. However, delegation must be used sparingly because it reduces the information aggregated through voting. In two different experiments -- a tightly controlled lab experiment and a perceptual task run online -- we find that subjects choose very high rates of delegation, and the theoretically possible improvements fail to materialize. The experimental evidence favors Direct Democracy, whether with or without abstention. We study the perceptual task, where signals' precisions are not known, both as a test of the robustness of the lab results and as an independent methodological contribution. We argue that tests under ambiguous information are valuable and under-used tools in studying collective decision-making.

PUBLICATIONS

The Use and Misuse of Income Data and Extreme Poverty in the United States, with Bruce D. Meyer, Derek Wu, and Carla Medalia. *Journal of Labor Economics* 39:S1, S5-S58 (2021). <https://doi.org/10.1086/711227>

Abstract: Recent research suggests that the share of US households living on less than \$2/person/day is high and rising. We reexamine such extreme poverty by linking SIPP and CPS data to administrative tax and program data. We find that more than 90% of those reported to be in extreme poverty are not, once we include in-kind transfers, replace survey reports of earnings and transfer receipt with administrative records, and account for ownership of substantial assets. More than half of all misclassified households have incomes from the administrative data above the poverty line, and many have middle-class measures of material well-being.

WORKS IN PROGRESS

Women, Men, and Pólya Urns: Underrepresentation at Equal Talent in the Absence of Discrimination, with Laura Caron and Alessandra Casella.

Abstract: In a world where the majority and the minority group have equal distributions of talent, where candidates are objectively and accurately evaluated, and no discrimination occurs, the underrepresentation of the minority group in prestigious positions is nonetheless highly sticky. If the sample of candidates from the minority group is numerically smaller, at equal distribution of talent, the most qualified candidate is more likely to belong to the majority sample, mirroring its larger numerical size. If future samples of candidates respond to the realized selection in the expected direction—increasing if the selection came from the sample, decreasing or increasing less if it did not—the higher probability of success in the majority sample will persist. We capture this process with a well-known statistical model: the Polya urn. The richness of existing results and the streamlined model allow us to study and compare different policy interventions. A simple app (<https://caron.shinyapps.io/Women-Men-Polya-Urns/>) allows readers to run their own experiments. Two robust results are that temporary affirmative action interventions have long-term equalizing effects, and that any decline in the quality of selected candidates is self-correcting, even while the intervention lasts.

CONFERENCES & INVITED SEMINARS

- 2026 AEA Annual Meeting, Harvard, MEA Annual Meeting, University of Chicago Mansueto Colloquium, UEA North American Meeting (*invited*), SEA Annual Meeting (*invited*)
- 2025 University of Arkansas, University of Alabama at Birmingham, University of Oklahoma, CEPR Political Economy Symposium, Behavioural Political Economy Workshop at LSE, Northwestern Political Economy Rookiefest, APSA Annual Meeting, UC Berkeley, University of Chicago Mansueto Colloquium
- 2024 Economics Graduate Student Conference, Washington University in St. Louis
- 2023 Student Workshop on Experimental Economics Techniques (SWEET), New York University
- 2022 Women in Economic Theory Student Conference, University of Chicago

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

University of Oklahoma: Instructor – Intermediate Microeconomics (2026)

Columbia University: Teaching Assistant – Intermediate Microeconomics (2020), Public Economics (2021)

RESEARCH & WORK EXPERIENCE

Lab Manager, Columbia Experimental Laboratory for Social Sciences	Jan 2023 – Dec 2023
Research Assistant for Alessandra Casella, Columbia University	Jul 2022 – May 2023
Research Assistant for Joseph Stiglitz, Columbia University	Jun 2020 – Dec 2022
Pre-Doctoral Fellowship with Bruce D. Meyer, UChicago Harris School of Public Policy (based at U.S. Census Bureau Headquarters)	Jan 2018 – Jun 2019
Analyst, Compass Lexecon, Antitrust and Competition Practice in Washington, DC	Aug 2016 – Dec 2017

SERVICE

Referee: International Journal of Economic Theory, Games and Economic Behavior, International Review of Economics and Finance

Columbia University: Student Workshop on Experimental Economics Techniques (SWEET), conference organizer (2023); Applied Microeconomic Methods Colloquium Organizer (2022-23); Undergraduate Mentoring Program, founder & organizer (2020-24), mentor (2022-2024); Association of Graduate Economics Students (AGES) Graduate Mentoring Program mentor (2020-22); Departmental Diversity Committee Graduate Student Liaison (2020-21)

AWARDS & FELLOWSHIPS

2024	Dissertation Fellowship, Columbia University
2023	Lewis A. Sanders Endowed Fellowship in Economics, Columbia University (for a PhD student in the department who demonstrates the potential to make important contributions to the field of economics)
2023	Wueller Pre-Dissertation Award: runner-up for best fourth-year proposal, Columbia University
2022	Vickrey Prize: runner-up for best third-year paper, Columbia University
2021-22	Trudy and Paul Woodruff Fellowship, Columbia University
2019-24	Economics Department Fellowship, Columbia University
2019-20	Provost Diversity Fellowship, Columbia University
2019-20	Dean's Fellowship, Columbia University
2016	David L. Fulton Prize (for orchestral excellence), University of Chicago
2015	Careers in Public Policy and Service Scholar, University of Chicago
2013-16	Klowden Scholarship (for distinction in extracurricular activities), University of Chicago
2012-16	Dean's List, University of Chicago
2012-16	National Merit Scholarship, University of Chicago

GRANTS

2024	Provost Diversity Fellows Small Grants Program (\$1,500)
2024	Program for Economic Research (PER) Research Summer Fellow (\$3,500)
2023	Program for Economic Research (PER) Research Summer Fellow (\$4,000)
2022	Program for Economic Research (PER) Research Summer Fellow (\$2,000)
2022	PER Award for Field or Experimental Research (\$3,500)
2021	PER Award for Field or Experimental Research (\$2,000)
2021	Program for Economic Research (PER) Research Summer Fellow (\$2,000)
2021	Columbia Experimental Laboratory for Social Sciences (CELSS) Grant for Graduate Student Projects (\$1,000)
2021	Micro Theory Initiative (MTI) Summer Funding (\$1,000)